

C

No language can claim to have had as much of an impact on computing as C has since its inception.

Like most programming languages, C was developed out of dissatisfaction with existing programming languages. Back in 1969 – when the idea of developing an operating system using a higher-level programming language was still novel – Dennis Ritchie was beginning to realise the shortcomings of the B programming language as he was working on recoding the Unix operating system to a new architecture in a higher-level language.

B was designed for a different computer generation – by Ken Thomson, who also contributed to C. The language was word-addressed instead of byte-addressed, and lacked floating point support. Since the early colonists of the digital era were not spoilt for choice as we are these days, they decided to create a programming language which better suited their needs.

Thus C was in use as early as 1972-1973, however this was the C before any serious efforts in standardisation were made, and would look odd to today's C developers. It was only with the publication of the 'The C Programming language' by Brian Kernighan and Dennis Ritchie in 1989 that C finally got a widely available manual for its syntax.

The first 'official' C standard that was ratified by the ANSI was published in 1989, and is still available in popular C compilers such as the GCC C compiler. This edition of the language is so popular that it is still the default